Over a Small Earthquake

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by nemali

Summary

If there was one thing Nathalie was confident about—arrogant, some might say, and she wouldn't have disagreed—it was that she knew Gabriel. Knew him like the back of her hand, inside out, forward and backward, and everything else under the sun.

But then, he starts watching her sleep.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

At this time of night, the kitchen belongs to Nathalie.

She sits at the counter, facing away from the clock—doesn't need it to show what she already knows. Papers spread over the counter as though she's staking a claim, as though she has the right to do such a thing. All the mansion's other staff members have long since gone home. Those who have somewhere to go.

Now, it's just her. Her and Adrien and Gabriel and Emilie. Her, trying to work. Adding more things to her to-do list than she's crossing off. The usual. Except for—

Footsteps.

Sometimes, in moments like this—when the lights are dim and the world is asleep and Nathalie's just tired enough to let her vision go hazy—she lets herself hope. Hope that maybe everything they're doing, everything they did, everything they will do, that it was all for something. That maybe the universe read her heart, for all that its biggest wish is scrawled in bold. Underlined a dozen times over.

That any moment, as the footsteps draw closer, a head of blonde hair will appear in the doorway. Bare feet padding over to Nathalie. Arms wrapping around her from behind. And Nathalie's vision would clear up. Lips would ghost against her ear, part like the brush of a feather, and a voice would say—

"Nathalie?"

She blinks, and the doorway is filled with Gabriel's figure. He doesn't turn on the light, for which she's grateful; him coming to join her in her world, instead of forcing her to adjust to his. He crosses the room—footsteps too heavy to be anyone else's—and comes to hover over her shoulder.

The weight of his gaze is heavy as he takes in the picture before him. Her shirt rumpled, collar wrinkled. The indent of her palm digging into her cheek. Her glasses slipping down her nose, because after the first dozen times of fixing them, she'd found it more efficient to simply leave them where they were. His eyes fall on the half-drunk mug of tea at her side, everything it represents: tea in the first place, instead of coffee or wine or any of the thousand others that don't hurt nearly as much to drink. She wonders if Gabriel can see the extra cubes of sugar she'd stirred in, even knowing how they would make her teeth ache.

"You're still up," he continues. Not surprised, but not pleased either. "Lots of work left?"

"I could say the same to you, sir," says Nathalie. She tips her head back to meet his eyes, wincing when the motion reveals a previously hidden crick in her neck. "It isn't like you to stay up so late."

Gabriel's hand comes up to settle at the base of her neck, and his fingers squeeze. Firm, efficient. Knowing exactly where the pain is, how best to coax it out. She does not thank him for it. Other people might find it cruel, the way he runs her ragged. Takes her pain away only

to return it tenfold. Nathalie doesn't. It's comforting to know where she stands in his life. There are no games with Gabriel; what you see is what you get.

"You didn't answer my question."

Nathalie huffs out a laugh. "I'm almost done," she tells him. "My boss wants me to finish preparations for next week's investor meeting by tomorrow."

"Rather harsh of him," Gabriel comments. "Perhaps you should tell him off."

"Maybe I will." She catches the way his mouth pulls at one corner. The haze of her spreading to him—this time of night, soft and clouded and theirs. The edges of them blurred; here, with his hands on her, her pain flowing toward him, she cannot tell where she ends and he begins. "Teach him a lesson."

"Ah, Nathalie, you should know there's no use in that." His fingers come up to stroke the soft skin of her earlobe. Exactly where a pair of spotted studs would be worn.

"And why's that?"

"Because lessons," says Gabriel, "are only worth something if you learn what you're supposed to."

Gently, Nathalie dislodges herself from his grip. Gathers all of her files in a neat stack.

"It's all right," she says. "My boss, he isn't all bad. I don't mind."

"Mind what, exactly?" Gabriel asks—voice sharper than before. Cutting through the haze.

Nathalie stands, turns to face him. Too close. He's caging her in against the counter. Nowhere to go. But it's only this close that she can see everything he must have been trying to hide. Her eyes are efficient—knowing exactly where the pain is. Anyone could spot the dark circles under his eyes, the ever so slight sag of his spine. But she is not anyone. Her gaze is magnetized to his tie. Looser than usual. Teeth marks on the silk.

"You were with her again, weren't you?" she whispers. Not an accusation, despite how much she tries to make it sound like one. "Gabriel, I know you—"

"It's late." He takes a deliberate step back. Letting her go. "You should go upstairs."

"And you?"

Gabriel hesitates, before he reaches out to her. Pushes her glasses up her nose, back to where they belong. "Not yet," he says, voice a murmur meant only for her to hear. "Go on, Nathalie. It's late."

The way he repeats those words—*it's late, late, late*—like a plea. At some point, Nathalie thinks, it all loops around. What time is it now? Is it late at night, or early in the morning? Late start, early ending.

She wants to say, *It's not late. Late for what? If I'm late, then what does that make you?*

"Good night, sir," she says, instead. Running, one would say. Doing her job, she would retort. Both are true.

Leaving him behind, she drags herself to the guest room—*her* room, she reminds herself, as she has done for so many years now. Some things are not easy to remember. Even her employers, for all they've taken from her, never deny her this. *It's your room, Nathalie,* they say. *It's always been yours.* Sometimes, she even believed them. If they say it enough, it'll come true. But that applies to the alternative, as well: an inescapable thought, that maybe her place here, her feelings for the Agrestes, the hold on her, it's all only temporary. Maybe one day, she'll wake up and be able to leave. To live a different life. To forget she ever met them.

For now, though, this is her room.

Through the bone-deep exhaustion that she fights off with every step, clumsily, she unbuttons her shirt, steps out of her slacks. Tosses them haphazardly to the floor. Tomorrow. She'll clean them up tomorrow. So much still to do. The Peacock eyes her from her bedside table. It'll kill her one day, Nathalie knows, but that day is not today. Not tomorrow, either. She needs to finish her work. Climbing into bed, Nathalie completes her day of contradictions. Alone in a double bed. Living in a guest room. An assistant who does not assist. Worker who does not work.

And now, she does not sleep, because Gabriel had not told her to. *Go upstairs.* Not, *Go to sleep.* Where do her desires end and his begin? Is there any difference between them—they, who know each other's pain better than their own?

Pleasure, too. Him, down in the basement while Nathalie was working. It's easy to picture it: Gabriel and Emilie, together. She's done it hundreds of times before. Standing outside their closed bedroom door. Smoking in the garden while their silhouettes were visible through the upstairs window. This is nothing new. Him, leaning forward with one hand pressed against the glass of Emilie's crypt. Pants undone, cock out. Other hand wrapped around the base, working himself furiously.

Nathalie's fingers creep downward. Past the waistband of her boxers, between her legs. Working efficiently, as she strives for in all capacities—this is no exception. Speeding up. Rubbing over her clit with pressure bordering on pain. Enough to feel.

Does it hurt? Emilie would have asked, faux-concern dusted over her features like a sprinkling of fresh snow.

Yes, Nathalie would reply, *but isn't that the point?*

No different than just one more cigarette before stepping back over the mansion's threshold. Adding just one more cube of sugar into her tea. Something to take the edge off.

So many nights had Emilie spent weaving fairy tales for Adrien—dragons and knights and magic. And at the beginning and end of it all, always a princess. One who could be kissed back to life. Could be saved by love. No matter what. Would Gabriel have kissed her, if there

were no glass between them? Would he press his lips to hers? Fingers coming to caress her cheek—soft, Nathalie's sure, so soft, even though Emilie isn't awake to anoint herself with creams and oils and everything else that she insisted enhanced her beauty, no matter how vehemently everyone else disagreed. Gabriel, then, pausing over her pulse. Almost too faint to feel, but maybe she'll wake up, if you want it hard enough. If you get down on your knees for her, part her thighs, show your devotion while she smiles down at you. You may be dragon or knight or prince, but in this moment, you are the wakener.

He's never gotten on his knees for Nathalie before. But then again, she's never wanted him to.

Nathalie thinks about Gabriel's fingerprints smudging the glass. She thinks about his tie between his teeth. She thinks about her own skin between those teeth.

Everything that happens next comes to her in parts: her body seizing; toes curling; teeth breaking through the skin of her bottom lip. The sound of her own breathing, echoing in her ears. And beyond that, something soft and rhythmic. Her heartbeat, she would think, if she couldn't feel the way it stutters in her chest, thudding against her ribcage as though demanding to be set free. Heavy, too, but that means nothing. It's a given if her heart were weighed against a feather, on the scales of the dead, which would come out on top.

Nathalie knows where she belongs.

Another thing she knows—the hallway floor right outside her door creaks. Something that usually never matters, for the guest room is far enough away from the rest of the house's occupants that sound doesn't travel. The taste of blood, sharp and salt and rust on her tongue, is enough to bring her back to life. How pathetic, that she'd gagged herself like so. Knowing that no one would hear her anyway. Wishing, perhaps, that they would.

But now, another creak. Not her imagination. Those heavy footsteps again, impossible to be anyone else's. Muffled, somehow, though. He isn't one to sleepwalk; more likely is that he'd forgotten to tell her something. Another demand to make of her—though. It isn't like him to come here, to be the type of man that exists in face-to-face interactions and in-person visits. Even Nathalie is no exception to his mannerisms; when she wakes, every morning, it's with a flood of messages from him, most of them not more than a few words. She's learned to translate his particular brand of shorthand—or, at least, she's learned to live with it. As she has with everything else about him.

It's almost instinctual, the need for Nathalie to bolt up and open the door for him. *Sir, did you need something?* But—

Something is off. The footsteps pause right outside her door, as though thinking. Debating. Nathalie does, too: what if her gag wasn't strong enough? Even though she has done far worse things with Gabriel—even though he has done far, far worse things *to* her—there are some things that she still wants to keep to herself. Wants to try, at least. Another way she tries to fool herself, another dream that will never come true. That maybe one day she will succeed in having some parts of herself that belong only to her and no one else.

Nathalie holds her breath, and in the silence, she can almost hear the way his fingers wrap around the doorknob. Leaving imprints behind, just like on Emilie's glass. The doorknob

turns. Slowly, so slowly. She's reminded of how she'd done the same thing before, when she was checking on Emilie in the later days of her illness. Wanting to see if she was asleep, but not wanting to wake her if she was.

No. Surely not. He must have simply forgotten something in her room. Her space. *Your room, your room, your room.*

The door opens like a stuttered inhale, and with it, Nathalie's eyes slam shut. He stands in the doorway for a moment; to his credit, when he begins to approach, it's with the careful steps of someone who knows he's intruding. Her closed eyes see the room through his open ones. Messy. No semblance of anything resembling order—tomorrow, she'd always told herself, for all that tomorrow never seemed to change anything. She's suddenly all too aware of the fact that her discarded clothes must be at his feet. Pictures him looking at them, now. At the implication they carry: that she's currently far less clothed under the covers than she was downstairs.

Nathalie doesn't know how much time passes as he stands there, but what she does know, without a doubt, is that he's looking at her. She fights to make her breath slow, even. A pretense of sleep. When he finally moves—after so long that she wonders if he was really there in the first place, if it was another dream she was unable to rip herself from—he steps closer. Toward her. Closer, closer. Nathalie holds herself still. Corpse-like. He leans in until his mouth is by her ear. Feeling the heat radiate off her body. Seeing the beads of sweat on her skin.

"Nathalie," he murmurs. Soft, so soft, as though returning to that hazy state they were in downstairs—had that really happened? Was that another dream? "Are you awake?"

She does not answer. For all that he is an open book to her, this is another side of him. A test. A king, checking just how loyal his knight is. So many times has Nathalie wondered what answers he expects from her in times like this. Is he always waiting for her to turn her back on him, a betrayal? Or does he simply like seeing the effect of his rule on her—testing how far his influence can stretch?

Further, now that there isn't another whose leash tangles with his.

Go upstairs, Gabriel had said. Not, *Go to sleep.* She is upstairs. She is not asleep.

But... another moment. She'll pretend for another moment before she reveals herself. He had a reason for coming here—as with everything he does. Nathalie wants to know what it is. A strange feeling, wanting. But it comes easy to her. And laying here, with the evidence of that want still drying on her fingers, she waits.

She's so centered in her body—in the room, the silence, the wanting—that the first brush of his fingers on her bare skin nearly makes her jump. As though he's the one with a crossbow, and her, held at arrowpoint. As far as touches go, it's rather innocent. Fingertips skate along the curve of her cheek, a barely-there touch. Searching, until he reaches his destination: her bottom lip.

He knows.

He knows what she's been doing here, just like she knew what he did as soon as she saw those teeth marks in his tie. What will he do, she wonders, with the drop of blood that surely must have stained his skin? Will he wash his hands of it, scrubbing until not a trace remains? Or something else, perhaps. Bringing those same fingers to his own lips, his tongue darting out to sweep that blood away. The same taste, sharp and salt and rust, in them both.

When Nathalie next opens her eyes, he's gone. The door closed. Her discarded clothes have been folded, placed on the foot of her bed.

In the morning, she does not thank him for it.

A week passes. The investor meeting goes well. Three more akumas are sent out, and each returns unsuccessful. There is still so much work to be done. Nathalie does not remember the last time she slept.

In the past, her dreams used to always follow the same pattern: things she wanted but could not have, places she could have gone but never did. People she could have been, instead of who she is. Now, Nathalie dreams while awake. Dreams of sending emails that never went out, booking appointments that were never confirmed.

"Nathalie," Adrien says carefully at breakfast one morning. "Are you all right?"

"Of course." Her eyes burn. "Everything is fine."

He doesn't give up. "It's just... you seem to be working a lot more lately. You've been busy. Maybe you should get some sl—"

"Everything is fine," she repeats. Another voice in sync with hers, as Gabriel's shadow falls over the table. Over her.

"Go on, Adrien," says Gabriel, in a voice that leaves no room for arguments. "Time for school."

"I don't suppose you're going to tell me that he's right?" Nathalie says when they're alone. Angry for some reason she doesn't quite understand. "That I should take a break?"

He considers her for a moment. "I wasn't going to say that."

"I double-booked the models for next season's show."

"I'm aware."

"I forgot to pay Adrien's Mandarin tutor," Nathalie continues. "I haven't replied to Madame Tsurugi's emails in four days. I didn't—"

"Is there a point to this, Nathalie?"

It's as though he's pricked her with his spindle; falling faster than any drop of blood would. A pounding in her chest, in time with the throbbing of her head. Her left, a heart. Her right, a

peacock. *Scream,* they both say. It's your fault. It's his fault. It's *her* fault.

Nathalie turns in her chair to face him. "I just don't see why you insist on pretending that I—"

"What is that?"

Interrupting her, again. Stoking whatever is burning in the pit of her stomach. Angry about everything except for what he should be angry about. She hasn't been working. She hasn't been assisting.

Because of *him,* a voice in her head whispers. Soft, crooning. Familiar. *He's making you work so hard. Is it because he doesn't trust you?*

He only gives me work because he trusts me to do it, Nathalie would reply.

Then why, it murmurs, *was he in your room?*

"The Peacock, Nathalie," Gabriel says, voice hard. "Why are you wearing it?"

His hand is on her shoulder, now. Holding her in place, forcing her to face him. There it is, that anger she wanted, needed, so desperately.

"You gave it to me, *sir,*" she retorts. "Do you want to take it back?"

"I thought we agreed. You wear it when I tell you to."

"Just like I do everything you tell me to," Nathalie says. "The models. Adrien's Mandarin tutor. Madame Tsurugi's emails. The Ladybug. The Black Cat."

If he is spindle, then she is crossbow. Each word an arrow poised perfectly to pierce; but Gabriel, man that he is, does not so much as stumble. She would question if he were human at all, had she not seen the way he bleeds so many times over. Heard the way he breathed standing over her bed.

His features are motionless, statue. He would fit right in the garden, she thinks.

She rises from her chair and pushes past him, shoulders brushing with too little force to make a difference, too much to be anything but what it is. She wonders if he'll stand in her way. Pull her back. Stop her, however necessary.

He doesn't.

Nathalie reaches up, away from his prying eyes, to her chest. Her fingers touch the Peacock, resting ever so lightly on its shining surface. Matching the imprints its previous owner left behind. Gabriel can go to the basement whenever he wants. Giving her this—when he takes everything else from her, everything except for what she offers—is the least he could do.

She doesn't take it off.

Those same footsteps again. The turning of the doorknob. That breathing, his and hers: even, measured, steady. Hers, because she pretends to be asleep. What is he pretending to be?

Again, Nathalie imagines him looking at her. At the Peacock, back in its place on the table. Is he satisfied, that she listened to him? Or angry at how long it took her to do so?

The whisper of his clothes as he leans down. His shirts need to be pressed, she reminds herself. If he weren't here, she would have rolled over and groped in the darkness for her tablet. In the blinding light it would let off, she would scrawl the words in a way just legible enough for herself to decipher in the morning. But it is nighttime, and Nathalie is supposed to be asleep—so she settles for remembering things the old-fashioned way. Plays them in her head enough, and eventually they'll be carved so deep that it'll be impossible to cut them free.

Press Gabriel's shirts. Finish the digital lookbook. Reprint the model lineup sheet. Place an order with the fabric supplier in Milan. In Istanbul. In New York. The shirts. Sleep. The emails. The Ladybug. The Black Cat. Book a haircut for Adrien. Wipe Emilie's crypt free of fingerprints. The fabric. Pay the tutor. Pay, pay, pay for it all. And at the top of the list—

"Nathalie," he says. "Are you awake?"

The shirts, the emails, the list, the crypt. No sleep. No waking. Because there's Milan, there's Istanbul, there's New York, there's the basement. A haircut. A lookbook. Emails, emails. Emilie.

The side of the bed dips. His knee bumps against her wrist. The bedsheets are getting wrinkled. Those need to be pressed, don't they? No, the shirts. Nathalie isn't wearing a shirt right now. What is there to press?

Something is pressing on her.

The sheets are being pulled away from her. Cold air on her arms, her stomach. Is the heater working? Does she need to call the technician? No, Nathalie, you should be asleep. There is no one to call. Fingers entwined with hers, now. Soft hands. Of course. Hers are, too. There is a tub of hand cream on the counter in Emilie's bathroom; though its owner has not used it in a year, it still runs out every few weeks. A permanent addition to the shopping list.

Nathalie's arm is pulled upward; a balance, to fight against the force and let herself go with it at the same time. Another contradiction, sleeping corpse that she is. Warm breath on her, as his lips brush against her wrist. They're chapped. Overworking himself, as usual. An edit to her own schedule—she needs to bring him water more often. Needs to buy lip balm for him. He'll protest if she tells him so, but if she, instead, leaves it on his desk, he'll use it.

Wet, now, as his tongue traces the veins under her skin. Those chapped lips she knows so well sucking at her skin. Her wrist reddening, darkening, as the imprint of his touch is left behind.

Finished with one wrist, he moves on to the other. Nathalie is limp in his hands, as she wonders: where else will he mark her? Perhaps he will drag his hips against the bed, next,

chase his own pleasure as he is so often wont to do. Use whatever parts of her he can reach to muffle his own sounds. Her throat, his tie.

His lips have moved further down to the crook of her elbow, where she's even more sensitive. Nathalie swallows a gasp. Fights against the urge to open her eyes. Even if she were to, she reminds herself, it wouldn't make a difference. Her glasses are tossed to the side. She hadn't turned the nightlight on. Would there even be anyone to see?

He's always liked leaving marks on her. Bent over his desk or pressed against the wall. Enough force to make tears spring out of her eyes; she never knows if that's because it's too much or not enough. She pictures it, everything that happens: the capillaries beneath her skin bursting at the pressure, unable to contain themselves. Blood cells leaking into the surrounding interstitial tissue. Collecting under the skin, making itself known.

Can he taste it?

Her arm is finally, mercifully released. Nathalie braces herself for what will come next. Her neck, always his favorite place. Right over where her pulse thrums under the skin, proof that she's alive. Her lips, too. Biting, sucking, until her hair is mussed, clothes rumpled, and the indents of him all over her skin serve as proof that she's been inarguably touched by him.

But. The longer she waits, nothing comes. He's watching again. Breathing harder, like it's she who has touched him and not the other way around. Two to a second, time moving twice as fast. The minutes get rolled around in Nathalie's head, and by the time she's caught up again, the other side of the bed is empty.

In the morning, Nathalie stands, unclothed, and catalogues everything that he has done to her. More bruises than she remembers him leaving, decorating her skin. Tendrils wrapping around her arms. She lifts her limp, corpse-like wrist to her mouth, lips pressing over the imprint of his. The marks throb like a heartbeat.

Eyeing the Peacock, she leaves it on her nightstand; she's carrying enough pain with her today.

He's angry with her.

Mayura folds her fan, holding it closed at her side. One feather lighter, now—her amok has long since been purified at Ladybug's hands, left to fly away in the wind. If she tried, she thinks she could still feel it. Call it back to her side; reluctantly, though. After it has felt absolution, salvation, exoneration, why would it return to her?

"I had to," she says. "You know that."

"What I *knew,*" Gabriel retorts, "is that I told you not to. And you blatantly disobeyed me."

Nothing I haven't done before, Mayura would say, if she didn't know how quickly doing so would set him off. *You couldn't have done it on your own. You needed me. I'd rather it happen to me than you.*

Instead, she steps forward. Gently takes his hand with her free one. He doesn't resist. He's let his transformation fall already, as though to persuade her to follow in his example. And she will—in a moment. Just one more. Another hazy moment, because the longer she stays transformed, the longer it takes for the rot to make itself known. A sickness that's already in her; that is undeniable. It has wormed its way into far greater women than she, after all.

"It won't be long," Mayura murmurs. "Just a bit more, and then it'll all be over."

Gabriel sighs. Breath trembling, ever so slightly. "Over," he repeats, drawing out the word. As though he has had the same dreams as her. "Will it, really? Or will it be just beginning?"

"Is that such a bad thing? A new beginning?"

If the Peacock could speak, it would crow in agreement. A beginning always requires an end, doesn't it? A life for a life. Everything coming full circle.

As though he's heard her thoughts, Gabriel's face hardens. His hand slips out of hers.

"Detransform, Nathalie," he says, turning to leave. "It's late."

Late, again. It seems like she's always running late, these days. Late with her help, with her assistance. And again, late with her sleep.

In this late night, Nathalie lies on one side of her bed. Coughs—muffled. If Gabriel cannot hear it, then it does not exist. The rest, too: the ache of her ribs, the shakiness of her legs, the headache that never, never seems to go away. Just a bit longer. Until they reach the end, and then, she can finally sleep.

But until then, she is free to dream.

About Emilie, tonight, though that isn't very surprising. It happens more often than not—more so on the days the Peacock rests on her chest. Awake, ahead. A thousand things between them, but glass is not one of those.

"I'm taking care of him, Emilie," Nathalie says to her. "Just like you asked me to."

Emilie laughs. *Do you really want to talk about* him *right now?*

No. No, she really doesn't.

Those soft, soft hands come to cradle Nathalie's face. Thumb stroking over the curve of her cheek. Emilie's eyes are bright, filled with life. Rested. She will never sleep again. No wakener necessary, but Nathalie would drop to her knees anyway, if only she could. But here and now, she does nothing without permission.

Lie down, says Emilie, and Nathalie does as told.

On her bed, in her room—hers, for she's never been with another here. The tables and the walls and the floor may be another matter, though. Nathalie's eyes flutter closed as fingers trace their way across her collarbone, over her stomach. Down, down, down.

Boxers again? Emilie asks, a ribbon of humor woven into her words. *Honestly, Nathalie.*

"Do you not like them?"

I didn't say that.

Into her waistband, now. She's wet; Emilie hums, pleased. Nathalie has long since passed the point of pretending. No use anymore, not when they know her so well. And in this time they get together, these few minutes stolen under the cover of night, the last thing she wants to do is waste any time with pretenses. Her body agrees, too. Her legs fall further apart, allowing Emilie's fingers to dance across her skin. Avoiding her clit, of course—not now, not yet. Not until Nathalie's panting and desperate and nearly crying for it.

Everything is a game with Emilie; what you see is never what you get.

Those fingers dip down to Nathalie's entrance, slipping in just enough to have her wanting more before they pull out again. Over and over, until Nathalie's gripping the sheets in her clenched fists. She does not reach out to Emilie, for she hasn't been given permission to touch her.

My, my, says Emilie. *You're rather tense tonight. Is there something you want from me?*

"You—" The pad of her finger bumps against Nathalie's clit, the brush of butterfly wings.

Me? She giggles. *How bold you are, Nathalie. Should I reward you?*

Eyes still closed, Nathalie shakes her head. "No," she whispers. "I haven't... I don't deserve it."

Deserve what, exactly? Emilie asks—voice sharper than before. Cutting through the haze.

Another list, and if Nathalie were to read off of it, it would take her all week to do so.

She hasn't responded; Emilie grows impatient. Not used to waiting, except for underground, surrounded by glass. The longest year of their lives. *Are you lonely down there, Emilie?* Nathalie wants to ask. *Forever craving touch? Or do you like it—art alone behind a barrier, never needing it?*

As if in answer, a finger slides into Nathalie. An impossibly slow stretch, the way her walls flutter around the intrusion. Long. Longer than usual. Strange things happen in dreams. Another finger, too. Then another. She isn't ready for three; her thighs tremble, fighting against the urge to close, self-preservation the last human thing about her. Retaliation: a thumb rubbing circles on her clit. The gentleness of earlier is gone. Now, the touches are harsh. Cruel, some would call them. Efficient, Nathalie would retort. Knowing exactly how much pressure to apply to have her opening up, thrusting those fingers in as deep as they'll go. Stretching her. She can feel them in her throat, she thinks. Behind her eyes. On her tongue.

Teeth scrape against her neck, and Nathalie chokes down a whimper.

Nathalie, Emilie murmurs against her skin. *Are you awake?*

Awake? Why would she be awake? How could she be anything other than awake—when those fingers are curling within her, thumb raking against her flesh like the blade of a knife? Searching, searching. And finding their mark, making her hips jolt, buck, lurch against the hand that's holding them down. Nowhere to go. Knowing exactly what her pleasure looks like, how best to coax it out.

This is not Emilie.

Further proof: teeth sink into her earlobe. Marking exactly where a pair of spotted studs would be worn. Her bruises have healed. Is he here to bestow new ones upon her? Does he think she's forgotten, in this time, who she belongs to? Who are the marks really for?

A memory returns to her, for all that she can hardly think right now. Months ago, Gabriel had met with another designer in his atelier. An attempt at a collaboration that quickly fizzled out. Nathalie was standing with her back against the wall, invisible, when the argument started, the other man disagreeing about a piece from Gabriel's old collection. And her, angry on Gabriel's behalf, ever his loyal knight. Emilie's eyes on her, expectant. *Go on, Nathalie. I trusted you to take care of him, didn't I? Do your job.* She'd turned her attention to her tablet, then, trying to go back in time far enough to find the design in question. But as it turned out, it wasn't necessary.

Gabriel's words from then echo in her head now. A mocking laugh. *Do you think I'd ever forget something I made with my own hands?*

A moan tears its way out of Nathalie's mouth, and with it, the fingers speed up. Angry with her. It's late. She was supposed to do something. What was—

"*Come,"* he commands, and it does not occur to her to disobey.

She teeters, falls off the edge between pain and pleasure, between sleep and wakefulness. Between alone and together. Thighs locking together, as though to keep him there. Nowhere to go. But this is not a reward, for she has done nothing to deserve it.

And he has always been stronger than her.

His fingers slide out of her, before disappearing altogether. Leaving her empty, marked. She cannot hear the footsteps over the sound of her own breathing. No point, now, in getting up.

It's late.

This, Nathalie thinks, may just be the most foolish thing she has ever done in her entire life. Her reflection stares back at her in agreement.

So many more sleepless nights, and each one ending the same way. She is marked head to toe, fading bruises side by side with fresh ones. Enough time for her to understand what this is: a game of Gabriel's own. One where she doesn't know the rules, for he's never told them to

her, and now she's scrambling to follow in his footsteps—or, to stand on the opposite side of him. But what are the sides? What is winning?

Does she even want to—she, who has fought for him to win for so long?

But what she does know is that it isn't a game if there are no players. A command that he's given her, and it's time for her to obey.

This isn't like him, she thinks. Perhaps—a replacement for the basement. A substitute. It should hurt, but... men have needs, do they not? Not her place to question that. All she can do—as she has done for so long, and will do for as long as the Peacock lets her—is give in to those needs. Support him. Do all that she can for him.

A bottle of perfume sits on the counter in front of her, pale pink and nearly empty. Just enough left for Nathalie's purposes. So many days spent with this perfume surrounding her that she can nearly taste it. Black currents and jasmine. The musk of white woods. Amber.

For dynamic women, she'd said, once, reading off the box, *with a zest for life. A love of stepping into the unknown.*

Sounds familiar, doesn't it? Emilie replied with a giggle. *Almost as though it were made for me.*

Not for Nathalie, which is all too obvious as she tentatively sprays it on her neck, her wrists. Over the bruises, layered. His and hers. The scent is strong, almost painful. It's been too long. A powerful perfume, or maybe it just seems that way to Nathalie—like Pavlov's dogs, conditioned to follow those white woods. Knowing who they would lead to. Any moment now, she'll walk in. Skin untouched, because he's never needed to mark her. Never mind the fact that she cannot bruise as she is behind glass, trapped in stasis.

In her own version of stasis, Nathalie waits. Lying under the covers, undressed again. Not dragon, not knight, nor prince nor princess. A wakener of a different sort, maybe. It's unfamiliar to be the destination at the end of the white woods instead of the traveler. She isn't suited for it. Some people—or one woman, in particular—can handle the wait, the confidence, the satisfaction of knowing how the story will end. Nathalie, on the other hand, fidgets, restless in more ways than one.

Ironic that now, she cannot bring to mind even a single thought besides ruminating over her own patheticness. No list for tomorrow, or the day after. Nothing but waiting for the sound of footsteps. The feel of breath on her skin.

Nathalie, he will say, *are you awake?* And tonight, Nathalie will say: *Yes. I am awake. I understand. I will be what you need me to be.*

There they are, on cue. Heavy. He's long since stopped hiding his footsteps. But that same anticipation still crackles in the air as he slowly pushes the door open. Comes to stand by the bed. By her. Can he smell it, this scent they both could—and have, so many times—drown in? Does he wish to again? A cheap replacement, Nathalie knows, and she has never pretended to be anything else, but if this is what he needs, then she can bear it.

Closer, now. He'll lean down, next, and go through the motions of their new routine together. Him leading the way, and her learning to adjust around him. Watching, calculating, until she understands. This is nothing new.

But—

No matter how long she waits, that touch never comes. Those lips—no longer chapped—don't meet her skin. He inhales slowly; she counts along. Four in, seven hold, eight out. Controlling himself. From what, Nathalie does not know. Those footsteps begin to walk—but not toward her. Away.

Surely he'll come back. A temporary deviation from routine, but he'll be back. She knows him.

Nathalie waits.

He doesn't come.

He doesn't come and he doesn't come and he doesn't come. Days and weeks and still, he doesn't come. A phase, perhaps, and now he's found his way back to the basement. Late nights becoming even later. Too late.

Everything else between them is the same: the work, the akumas, the failure. A win, maybe, that her room is hers again. Her time, her sleep, everything else that he's taken from her. Lines drawn in the sand between a king and his knight, and there is no room for overlapping, not any longer.

Then why, Nathalie wonders, does it feel like she's lost something?

If there was one thing she was confident about—arrogant, some might say, and she wouldn't have disagreed—it was that she knew Gabriel. Knew him like the back of her hand, inside out, forward and backward, and everything else under the sun. Knew that any time he was ready to trek through those white woods, she would be there at his side. And knew, despite it all, that he wanted her there.

Now, it's as though everything has been turned on its head. Hung upside down from a yoyo. An amok that refuses to return to her.

Nathalie is no stranger to provoking her boss—now, she attempts to do so not out of any sort of satisfaction, but something that feels uncomfortably, familiarly like desperation. Her natural state. During the days, she pulls her sleeves higher, forgoes a button or two. No concealer to cover the bruises on her chest, her wrists.

I know what you did to me.

Gabriel hardly spares them a glance. *Is there a point to this, Nathalie?*

Marks fade. On her chest, the Peacock burns. The game that she's lost, the test that she's failed—she wonders if it ever existed at all. No footprints in the carpet, no fingerprints on the

doorknob. Tomorrow, she used to think. Fooling herself, for if there's one thing she knows, it's that tomorrow will never change anything.

All she has is the night.

And in this night, Nathalie wakes. Opens her eyes, puts on her glasses. When she sleeps now, it's only for a bit at a time. Always jolting awake, thinking she hears footsteps. An affirmative ready on her lips, an answer to a question that is no longer being asked.

It's late, he always says. True. But maybe it's not *too* late.

She rises, dresses haphazardly. Her, now, whose footsteps are muffled, whose fingerprints decorate the doorknob. She swings open the door, and stops in her tracks. Blinks once, and then again. Wonders if she is really awake at all.

"Gabriel," says Nathalie. "What... are you doing here?"

"You talk in your sleep," he says, tilting his head back to meet her eyes.

It's as though he's spoken a different language; she blinks at him, wondering if his words are meant as an accusation. Her fault that he's here, on the floor in front of her bedroom door.

What do I say? Nathalie would ask, if only the answer weren't written all over his face. Scrawled in bold. Underlined a dozen times over.

"Is there a point to this?" she asks instead, the words slipping out of her mouth like too-sweet tea. Something she wouldn't have said otherwise, but she blames it on the time, the place. The exhaustion. The haze that only seems to rear its head at times like this.

The sound of his laughter reaches her before regret does. This sound, at least, she knows: underneath the amusement, an underlayer of embarrassment. He hadn't expected to be found like this. To be caught.

Doing what, though, Nathalie doesn't know.

"Am I too loud?" she presses. "Does it bother you?"

Bags under his eyes. He's not a young man anymore; the floor cannot be nearly as comfortable as he makes it look. Tentatively, she comes to crouch before him. A hand rising to wrap around his neck, settling at the base, and her fingers squeeze. Firm, efficient.

"It's all right," he says. "It isn't all bad. I don't mind."

"You are an impossible man," Nathalie informs him.

"Am I?"

"Gabriel," she says, "are you awake?"

Understanding flashes in Gabriel's eyes. His gaze darts down to her neck, her chest, her wrists—mapping out the path that his lips had taken, over and over.

"I thought you would ask," he murmurs.

"Would you have answered?"

"Not then, maybe." He turns his head away from her, and her hand follows the motion. "Not when I didn't know, myself."

Nathalie considers him. "And now?"

Gabriel sighs. Heavy, the sound pressing down on her. "You haven't asked."

He's surprisingly pliant in her grasp. Soft, almost. The way he sits outside her door as though he's done it a thousand times before. Skillfully avoiding the creaking floorboard. Knowing that she talks in her sleep—this distance, through the door, just enough to hear it. The Peacock.

"I don't need to," says Nathalie.

Not anymore. *Go upstairs.* Not, *Go to sleep.* The truth carves itself deep into her skin, and this, she knows, is one mark that will not fade.

You're afraid that if I fall asleep, I won't wake up again.

Carefully, Nathalie stands. Holds herself still under the weight of his gaze. Taking her rightful place by his side in the white woods.

"It's late," she says, offering him her hand. "And my room is right here."

When his fingers intertwine with hers, he does not thank her for it.

End Notes

I Have Always Confused Desire With Apocalypse

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